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Kent Jordan

Flautist Kent Jordan is making his contribution to jazz as a performer and educator. He graduated from the Eastman School of Music in 1984 and has taught at the New Orleans Center for the Creative Arts. Kent has recorded as a leader of his own group and has shared the stage with Nicholas Payton, Wynton Marsalis, Kevin Eubanks and with members of his own musical family, including his father, saxophonist Kidd Jordan.

Kent was interviewed in Rome, New York on August 22, 2006 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Rome, New York with Kent Jordan. Thanks for being here.

KJ: I'm glad to be here. This is an honor and a privilege, it really is.

MR: Do you think of yourself as a flautist or a flutist?

KJ: Well you know you get that question a lot. I think James Galway answered that question for everybody, you know you're just a flutist and every once in a while you might flaut.

MR: Okay, that's good. It's like the difference between a violin and a fiddle player.

KJ: Right. A violin and a fiddle player. You know most violinists call themselves fiddle players, so yeah that's an interesting dichotomy there.

MR: I was talking to Clyde Kerr just now about the family tradition in New Orleans. It's unbelievable to me, the number of families. It's almost like a family that would always have carpenters or bricklayers or some families have musicians.

KJ: That's an interesting analogy. I've never really thought of it that way. You know I guess in certain areas of the country where certain livelihoods or occupations would dominate, and obviously in New Orleans the music has always been a dominant influence in terms of our culture. And I think that's one of the reasons why families have evolved so, because outside of my family, the Jordan family, were my mom grew up in a family of 16 kids, if you can believe that, but everybody played an instrument or sang. So it was a really great experience to come up with my father, you know, learning music in Crowley, Louisiana of all places, the Cajun influence, the Zydeco influence, and my mom learning to play the piano, playing Beethoven and playing Schubert and Chopin, which are some of her favorite composers. In fact it's really interesting because Alvin Batiste, the famous clarinetist, introduced my mother and my father to each other because he was seeing my mom's sister. So you know it gets strange and peculiar. But yeah music is sort of like — for lack of a better description — a fulcrum in a lot of families in New Orleans. It really

MR: You know when you see promo written about people, if you're from New York or you're from New Orleans, most likely the promoter or the people who write that copy are going to mention that, especially if you're playing out of town. Does it mean something to you? Do you think it's important that you're from New Orleans as far as the way you play?

KJ: I think that's a really tough and interesting question. Because what happens is that sometimes you forget about other cities. Say for instance Detroit, where people like Joe Henderson, the Joneses — Elvin Jones, Hank Jones and Thad Jones — Kenny Garrett, Ron Carter, James Carter, Regina Carter —

MR: Billy Mitchell.

KJ: Right Billy Mitchell. I don't want to leave anybody out, I'll be here all day. And the funniest analogy that I can give you with that is one time I was talking with Max Roach and he said, "You know the only person I know from New York is Sonny Rollins. He's the only one I know who is from New York and everybody else is from somewhere else." It was really interesting. And I don't know how true that it is but I think other cities in their own little way have added to the music. Like Los Angeles is sometimes forgotten. You know I was talking with the great drummer Chico Hamilton. And he was telling me that in his class was Dexter Gordon, Charlie Mingus, Buddy Collette, okay?

MR: Right.

KJ: And himself, not to mention anybody — Ernie Andrews you know? So New Orleans doesn't have a monopoly on great musicians but I think in terms of sometimes the lineage, when you think about Louis Armstrong or King Oliver and all of these people, sometimes in a peculiar kind of way, it's the beginning. And so we have influenced these other cities of the world. And it's sort of like a special kind of relationship I think we have with other cities.

MR: Before you left for Eastman, we'll get to that in a minute, but was there enough work for you as a musician in New Orleans?

KJ: Yeah it was weird. I mean when I was in high school I was performing with Ellis Marsalis at a club, you probably are familiar, called Lu and Charlie's. I don't know if you're familiar with Lu and Charlie's?

MR: No.

KJ: Oh well let me mention this in the archive for you. Lu and Charlie's was a very interesting venue. It was a club. It was owned by, oh my good friend, now Charlie Bering, who passed away maybe about six years ago. And Charlie was actually one of the producers of the Jazz and Heritage Festival but he had a club when I was in high school. And people like Alvin Batiste performed there, Ellis Marsalis performed there, all of the local New Orleans jazz giants performed there. And that was my first baptism into jazz

and people like James Black on drums and all these wonderful musicians. I mean I was like in heaven, I was like a child in a candy shop. You know, like studying with Ellis during the daytime and performing with people like Alvin Batiste, I was still at that time performing with my father and you know they were bringing other musicians who love New Orleans, like Cannonball Adderley —

MR: Oh, my hero.

KJ: So I met Cannonball when I was in junior high. Man he was, you know, just so down to earth. Sometimes you have these expectations of like when you think about somebody like Cannonball, like a God you know. But you meet him and he's just as genuine as his music was. And that's the thing that really impressed me about a lot of the musicians who I met.

MR: Why the flute?

KJ: My cousins played flute and I started actually on the alto saxophone, as you know my father is a saxophonist. And for some strange reason I never really had a connection with the alto saxophone. But I started on the flute first, switched to the alto, went back to the flute and there was some kind of connection that I actually made with the instrument the second time around. The interesting thing about the flute is it's a really tough instrument in terms of holding it. And I tell that to a lot of young flutists like who want to start playing the flute like when they're in the second or third grade, don't start, start on piccolo. Because you have a tendency to grab the horn because it's big. It doesn't look big physically but when you think about it, it's really humongous. And so when I go around and I see a lot of young students I can tell, yeah, you started really early because you're grabbing the horn — you're not holding the horn, because you're struggling with it. And somebody, you might remember this, came up with the idea of actually curving it around to shorten it.

MR: My daughter did that.

KJ: All right, and the reason why is because you see you go from here to here. The position. And somebody figured that out. And so basically I had a lot of cousins who were great flutists. I mean flute, at that time, was an instrument that fit in the marching band, there really wasn't a lot of like youth orchestras around during that time so basically when you played the flute you were going to play in a band, a marching band, concert band. And they really excelled at playing the instrument and I learned a lot from them. And my father was very supportive, because he played a little flute at the time because he was always — I mean I remember him with the bassoon, the saxophones, the oboe, the flute. Because he would say well you never know what you have to play if somebody comes in town with a show, you know, to have to double on all these instruments. And so

And they always talk about it being very difficult. Because in actuality the flute is closer to the trumpet than the saxophone in terms of the embouchure if you think about it. You know because you have that open kind of focused, centered kind of an embouchure that you have to deal with. And in fact I knew of a couple of trumpet players who actually doubled on flute and trumpet which I thought was really interesting.

MR: Interesting, yeah. And so you went through the whole classical repertoire?

KJ: Right. I went through all of that. Studied at NOCCA with Ellis but actually that was interesting because at NOCCA even though I played with Ellis I was studying classical music and I was studying with one of the principal flutists in the New Orleans Symphony Orchestra, Richard Harrison. And Richard was a product of Juilliard and Europe and studying independently in Europe with different people. And you know he got me ready to go to Eastman. And I went to Eastman and studied with Bonita Boyd there, I'm sure you're familiar with Bonita Boyd, a great flutist. And it really interesting because when I was auditioning to get into Eastman James Galway had just accepted the offer to teach there. And when I was about to go they said that no, he was going to start concertizing and I mean he was just on the verge — he was just being introduced to the American audience during that time. And it was actually good that I didn't study with him because a lot of the flutists who studied with him said it was a nightmare because he was there for like maybe two weeks and then he'd have to fly in all these other flutists from all over the country to study so it was—

MR: No consistency.

KJ: No consistency. And you know it didn't really last six months so it was a weird kind of situation. But Bonita was a great instructor for me.

MR: Rochester is a pretty good music town also, wasn't it?

KJ: Oh man, I used to go out — I forget the name of this place, where Bill Dobbins used to perform. It was a little club not far from the dormitories.

MR: It wasn't the Pythod, was it? I think that was way back.

KJ: It was like — it had a French name. It was just one of those places where we used to go and listen. I used to listen to him because he was like really knowledgeable especially in terms of bop. And during that time as you know, he transcribed a lot of Keith Jarrett's music, he was very — in terms of influencing me — he was really interested in, at that time, trying to combine sort of like the new thing with the classical thing. And actually on my senior recital he played the Franck Sonata with me, which is an incredible piano part. In fact the piano part is harder than the flute part. It's one of those pieces that's weird because violinists play it, cellists play it, flutists play it. You know it has sort of like that really interesting flavor about it that a lot of people when they hear it they want to

handle it. And I saw him for the first time, well I've seen him a couple of times, but at the IAJE convention in Long Beach, California about a year and a half ago. And we were talking about how in music you really should concentrate on the instrument first and not really call yourself a jazz musician or a classical musician but really concentrate on the fundamentals because that's how he was taught. I mean but he was very knowledgeable in terms of jazz, did a lot of transcriptions, did great arrangements, but he's really knowledgeable about the piano. He really, really, really is.

MR: When you were at Eastman what was your thought about post-Eastman?

KJ: I don't know. I mean when you finish school you have to gig, you have to find a gig. It was really interesting when I was leaving school a lot of my fellow alumni were getting offers to play in orchestras like the New York Phil and the San Diego Phil during that time, and various orchestras. But what sort of influenced me was my teacher in New Orleans, Richard Harrison, told me something that I'll never forget, he said, "Kent, just remember, if you want to be in an orchestra it's like being in an army. You have to go where they go." There's really no — and that sort of made a really deep impression on my consciousness because even though I love classical music and I love all music, I love to listen to all types of music, I wanted to be free. I didn't want to be in a situation where I had to move when somebody else said move. Because I really wanted to explore what music meant to me versus well getting ready to play two or three times in a week, which is — I'm not knocking it — but I knew for me that wouldn't be something that I would enjoy over a period of time. And I really wanted to focus on exploring music. I mean playing the type of music that I felt gave me joy, for lack of a better word. Things that I really wanted to do. Things that I wanted to pursue. In other words, I knew that certain things had already been done and they were like you take that career path of playing in maybe a small orchestra and getting good enough so that you can audition for a bigger orchestra and that whole thing. You know there's a lot of people who burn themselves out in that kind of a situation. You know, and some people really enjoy it. But for me, it was like no, I'd just rather listen and check it out and do some things that are a little bit different.

MR: When I look at most classical musicians and rehearsals and so forth, I never get the impression that they were enjoying themselves. Maybe they're just not supposed to smile or something, I don't know.

KJ: That's an interesting observation. But you know what I can tell you about that. Because at Eastman I mean I had to do a lot of that, I mean obviously playing in operas and playing in the various pieces that we were going to perform for that semester. And basically I think what happens is that you always are in a preparation mode. You're

Mozart or Beethoven wanted that to happen. I think what they wanted to happen was yeah, you know, learn the music. Obviously you have to learn the notes. But you have to get to the music some kind of way. And so what happens is you're constantly trying not to peak. Because you might only be playing this piece, you know, two or three times. And so if you're in a rehearsal situation, you know, it's like well how do you get to the point where it just happens spontaneously, like — for lack of a better definition — like when a group of five jazz musicians are playing you never know what's going to happen from night to night. Especially if, I remember like playing with Elvin Jones and Elvin told me something that was really important when he was with John Coltrane. He said, "You know sometimes John used to just walk up on the bandstand and start playing. And we didn't know what he was playing, and we'd have to follow him. And we would play for hours and hours like that, every night." He said, really. He said really it was sometimes people think the music was rehearsed and it wasn't rehearsed, he might bring in a sketch and we'd have to follow what he was doing, and the music was very, very spontaneous, if you can imagine. And I think in classical music the problem sometimes is they lose that spontaneity. You see? And that's not to take away from the music but just think about it. If you've been in an orchestra for 30 years and unfortunately you're not exploring a lot of new music and you're playing the war-horses every year, you're bringing in the same soloists so you pretty much know, you've played that piece a thousand times maybe. And it gets old. And you really have to be careful sometimes what you wish for. Because at the time I can remember there was this big thing happening and that was Pierre Boulez was leaving the New York Phil when I was in school and he was really trying — at that time you remember — to introduce a lot of new music, a lot of new composers. And they got rid of him. Because it was like no, we want to hear our Beethoven, we want to hear our Mahler, we want to hear Bruckner, we want to hear Brahms. And that's not to take away from their music but you know, now I know if Brahms was alive today he'd be like what are you guys doing?

MR: Really? You're playing that again?

KJ: You're playing that again? I wrote that 300 years ago, come on. You know? What's happening? And I don't think classical musicians would understand that. They probably look at me like I'm really crazy but you know I tell people all the time if Mozart or Brahms or Beethoven or those guys were alive they wouldn't be doing that. They'd probably be hanging out at some club, you know trying to, yeah, "I might learn how to swing. Really? Yeah, let me check that out." I'm just saying I mean it would be what's ever is the cutting edge because they were the cutting edge, you see, during that time. And sometimes we forget that. We sort of lose sight of that. That it's great, great, great

music wasn't really being played every night the way it's being played now. You know so think about that. That's kind of strange.

MR: I sometimes have to remind myself about people being sort of on the cutting edge when they're young. Because I've had the privilege of doing interviews with a lot of elderly musicians now and I forget that they were young once and that they were really ripping it up and they were progressive and all that.

KJ: Yeah that's right.

MR: It's easy to forget that. On the other hand sometimes I forget that people like your father can put out a record like the last thing he did, "Palm of Soul," and he's like out there.

KJ: Right he is. Yeah. Well that's his personality though. See and that's what I love about jazz more than anything, or music period, that at the heart of it it has to express what your personality is really all about. Because genuinely that's what people are checking out. I mean for the novice who knows nothing about analyzing or being analytical, you know, they're not going to know anything about dominant seventh from a, you know, they don't. But when they see somebody really playing what they want to play and they can see that person really involved and it's something that they want to check out, I've seen that happen a thousand times with people saying yeah I may not understand it, I may not like it, but you know what? This person's personality is very engaged in what he's doing so I'm going to stay here and check out what's going on. And I can really appreciate that.

MR: Have you found a group of musicians or a format so far that best helps you get your personality out there?

KJ: It's interesting, I do. Sometimes I have some things where I just do flute and strings and I've done some concerts like that where I play classical and jazz music combined, some interesting compositions that I've done with a friend of mine who teaches at the University of California Santa Barbara, Earl Stewart, who is a great composer and arranger and teacher. And we talked about concepts that combine different idioms. And I have my own group where I just sort of try and combine an acoustic and the electric combination because I think our senses go in that direction. You know we can't really — we can't discount the electric. What I mean by that like the synthesizers and that type of sound in a way, you know what I mean? And I try to combine that in certain areas and even deal with things, dealing with vocals and voice, that type of thing. And for me being a flutist, it's you know, there's not a lot of flute players. This music didn't evolve with the flute, saxophone, trumpet combination. You know it was always people like Hubert Laws out there or Herbie Mann or who else am I, I don't want to leave anybody out, but just the flute is sort of like in its own way a kind of an oddball instrument in jazz. It's never been really one of those kind of instruments. People like it when they hear it but as

a jazz, a bone fide jazz instrument, it's sort of always been, I think, relegated to like the sideline instrument.

MR: Yeah. It's usually been a second for things. It's still like almost like you have to qualify it somehow. But you mentioned some great people. Are those — you know I was listening to your CD here, "Essence"—

KJ: Oh, okay.

MR: And I was listening to it and I said I think Hubert Laws listened to you.

KJ: Oh no, no I listened to him. Oh no, no, no, no. He's been a great influence because obviously he had the training in Juilliard and Julius Baker and all that stuff and he is an interesting person because he always explored pop music, jazz music, Latin music, classical music. And he was a great influence because he, in a way, his music always reflected to me interesting dichotomies. Because you take a CD that he did entitled "Morning Star," Rogers Grant, great composition. I mean a beautiful arrangements by Don Sebesky. So he was always to me always trying to deal with the pinnacle of the music and really bringing out the best in what he was playing during that time. And I could really, really, I have a deeper appreciation for it now because I think a lot of times what happens in a recording type situation is musicians get together and say okay, you know, we're going to do these tunes in two or three days, we'll play the heads, we'll practice our solos and run a tape and hopefully we'll have a CD at the end of it. And I think very few musicians realize that you really have to deal with arrangements, you have to deal with color, you have to deal with sound, you have to deal with tempos of tunes, how you want it to sound. I mean I'm really at my best when I'm dealing with those types of things. So you know he meant a lot to me in terms of my development, he really did.

MR: I'm trying to remember the name of the record , "Sunflower"?

KJ: Oh "Wild Flower."

MR: "Wild Flower." With the strings?

KJ: Exactly right.

MR: Oh that's a beautiful—

KJ: Well actually he gave me all of the arrangements off of that CD. And I performed tunes like "Pensativa," John Murtaugh did "Equinox," "Motherless Child." He just called John Murtaugh and said yeah, give Kent the arrangements. And I performed some of those things when I do the flute and string combination. I'll send you the concert, I did it live, so you can hear it.

MR: That's great. And he doesn't — did I hear something that he doesn't perform in clubs anymore or something like that?

KJ: No, he rarely performs in clubs. You know, festivals maybe, you know you see Hubert. I haven't spoken with him in a while but I'd love to, hopefully sometime maybe get together and do something.

MR: Did your father anticipate and then encourage you to pursue music as a career?

KJ: He teases us about that now but I think in his own way, you know, for him to have all of us out here performing and doing our thing, there's a certain sense of pride in that. What any family, you know like you take Ellis and his kids, you know Branford and Wynton and Jason and Delfayo, are you know, I don't know, I just think that parents are — they say one thing but behind the scenes they're still like pushing. They want to see their kids do well. Any parent wants to see their kid do well. And for us I think again going back to New Orleans, going back to traditions, going back to our influences, how we were taught, what we were taught and the way that we were taught, it's almost if I can say this, it's just expected that you were going to be a musician. You know, you're gonna — you have to keep up the tradition, you have to keep following, you have to keep the path for other musicians who are going to be coming. Because the same was done for you and so we sort of had this — for lack of a better definition — a tradition, that we follow. Hopefully it will become better because it's about making it better. Obviously we've gotten a lot of recognition these past couple of years in terms of the musicians who have come from there, but in a lot of ways I think sometimes it can work against you. Because New Orleans has such a strong tradition and traditional music that sometimes it's hard to break out of that. You know you look at my father, and if you didn't know he was from New Orleans, he sounds like out there by himself in a way. But to answer your question I think no, he really never discouraged us from doing what we wanted to do. I mean he spent a ton of money on private lessons.

MR: Okay, well there's something to that.

KJ: Right.

MR: I want to go back to that bit you were just talking about in that people may make preconceptions about you as a musician because you come from New Orleans and you play jazz, well then you must play —

KJ: "Basin Street Blues" —

MR: Yeah, all that.

KJ: And actually that's really interesting because, well a lot of people, and hopefully you'll get a chance to introduce, well interview, Harold Batiste. I don't know if you're familiar with Harold Batiste. But Harold was sort of like the person who was teaching Ellis and Nat Perrillat and all these other people tunes that Charlie Parker was writing. I mean he was a person transcribing in New Orleans and well this is what Bird played and this is the

influencing Alvin Batiste, Ellis Marsalis, Ed Blackwell and all these other people. And it's really interesting because you just never know, you know, who's going to be the person with the invisible hand behind the scene telling people well this is the music, this is the new thing, this is what's going on. It's really interesting.

MR: Do you have a description of what it is you're trying to do with your music?

KJ: Hmm. That's an interesting question, a description. I would hope that it would be fresh. I hope that — I think for me what I fall back on is what Duke Ellington said about music, there's only two types of music: good music and bad music. I really believe that to be true. And not so much bad music but something that maybe you don't like. And you know there's all kinds of things that I may not really like that I listen to and I'll check out like a student of mine or a friend of mine who may be listening to something. And I'll just listen just to make sure that I don't have any buffers that's not allowing me to experience what they're experiencing before I really, you know, take off my analytical hat or put my two cents in and say, you know, I really don't like that. Because sometimes we just have a tendency to react viscerally to something because we don't understand it, because we don't like it or because it may have rubbed us the wrong way. So for me the words are say phrases good and bad and maybe just to keep the spontaneity in music is sometimes a very difficult thing to do. To keep something that you played a million times spontaneous. That may mean a change to the harmony or change the melody a little bit or to try to work the rhythm a little bit different or even play it in a different key. You know, something that will enable me to find a piece of myself in that music so that I can convey it to the listener or try to convey it to myself. You know it's really like a constant search. You know if anything that I've gotten from John Coltrane's music is that he was always searching. He might be playing something like "My Favorite Things" and you hear one night and then you listen to another night or you listen to it on another CD and it was like man, he found something new you know. I mean he really was searching for something. Or you know when you listen to Miles Davis you know you hear that quality in the esoteric mind at work is really an interesting thing.

MR: You do a certain amount of composing?

KJ: Actually what I've been doing lately has been — I'm not really a writer in that sense but I'm sort of like a person who likes to analyze music a lot. I think sometimes we get lost in the nomenclature. Analysis is very important. I think if you can analyze then you can compose. For me right now I'm finding that arranging, analyzing and practicing certain things — I mean it's like certain devices that I know that work, that will work. And so the thing is to take those things that you know work and put them into some kind of musical context that will make it seem seamless. What I mean by that is for instance if you listen

perfect, I mean perfection. And when you really start — and then sometimes, in other words, you analyze them and you say why is this fitting like this? Why is this — but at the same time it's still emotional, you know what I mean? In other words it's not just a bunch of notes thrown on the paper and he knows how the violin, the cello and the viola and all these things interact but how do you make music from these things? And they get lost in it. I mean that's what's interesting to me. Like if you're analyzing like a John Coltrane solo and you get all of the notes, everything is lining up, but there was something very emotional about it. And then at the same time there's something very analytical about it. And so how do you bring those two things together so that they're very seamless. And that's what I try to convey to my students, I say you know you really have to deal with emotion but you also have to deal with the analysis. The analysis is very important. Don't get too far away from the analysis.

MR: Does that same thing apply in improvisation for you? How much theory do you think a student needs to be able to improvise?

KJ: A lot.

MR: You think a lot.

KJ: You never can have enough. You never can have enough because as you discover certain things harmonically that can happen and melodically — see to me rhythm, melody and harmony are one. They are not separate. You know we teach them separately but they're really one movement together. They function as one. When you start to break them down into the different boxes that's when you start to lose it. Because there are certain things that might be happening melodically that has nothing to do with the harmony and certain things that might be happening rhythmically that may have nothing to do with the melody but when you put them together they function as one you see. And to me that's the things that are really interesting like when you start discovering certain things about how harmony functions and how melody and all these things really come together then they really become one because you're not thinking about them in separate departments you see. I can tell you from school we learned those things wrong. We had to go to harmony, you go to dictation, you go to — no you should just really — and I'm sure there's some smart people who figured it out, you know it's really just like one thing that you have to really deal with, put them all together so you can see how they function together. I mean can you imagine if when Ravel wrote Bolero that he was still thinking about sixteenth century harmony and treatises and terms, you know, parallel fourths and fifths? Come on. He would have never wrote it.

MR: That's right. Ooh I can't write that.

KJ: No you can't write that. I mean I can't have the piccolo and the bassoon in seconds

MR: I guess that's the magic of it, those moments when people find things that didn't work before and make something out of it.

KJ: Oh yeah and that happens a lot. I mean I'm still discovering things. I mean we were playing like a Kurt Weill's tune, a Kurt Weill's tune today at the jazz camp and I was trying to find a different harmonization on "Mack the Knife," you know that will keep it fresh than what people would play. I mean you could take even very simple things and find from your analysis well this is what we'll do differently to reharmonize this and still make it beautiful but make it subtle so that when people hear it, they won't even know that you've reharmonized the tune.

MR: I brought a little example of you here.

KJ: Oh, okay, uh oh which one?

MR: Do you think you could guess what I picked?

KJ: You probably picked something like a —

MR: That's an unfair question.

KJ: Did you pick, uh, Thelonious Monk "Well You Needn't?"

MR: I can't believe it, you're psychic.

[audio interlude]

MR: Why didn't you do it fast?

KJ: That's interesting.

MR: Okay now I have to — first of all like how did you do that, but were those changes, I mean those half-step things going back for forth —

KJ: Right.

MR: Pretty darn quickly.

KJ: Right.

MR: Do you somehow try to find a scale or a sound that's both?

KJ: Yeah. And that gets back to, again, my analysis. You know like when you're analyzing harmony or the melody, see those things fit together. I mean in other words if you're just thinking about it okay, going down in half-steps you know, you'll miss it. Dominant sevenths by their very nature, I don't know if I'm getting too analytical. They're really interesting when you think about them because they have different qualities about them in a dominant seventh, especially when John Coltrane was dealing with them. They had like, to him, three qualities. They could be minor sevenths at certain times, or function as minor sevenths, or minor nines or elevenths. Then you could use them in terms of half-diminishes. And then you can use them just in terms of, because they actually are major chords and didn't have a dichotomy about them because you're just dealing with the dominant seven, they can be major and they can be half-diminished if you think about it,

is the major chord and then G-B-flat, you know, E-G-B-flat which is the half diminished. And then if you start extending them then you know they have minor qualities about them, you know like say for instance I remember when I was analyzing "Blue Trane" and there was one passage on like a C7 type of chord where John played a minor eleventh. And so he played like B-flat, D-flat, F, A-flat, E-flat, G, right? And so I'm analyzing and I say well wow, well B-flat is the seventh, the D-flat could either be you know the flat nine, the F is the eleventh, the A-flat is the sharp five in relation to the dominant seventh. You follow me? The C is the tonic again, the E-flat is the sharp nine, right? What am I leaving out? E-flat — G, well goes back to being the fifth. So basically he saw where a dominant seventh, if you start it from the seventh running an arpeggio from the seventh, you could have these extensions that function as a minor eleventh but against a dominant seventh. You follow me? So that was very important to him, like to find those different functions and to make sure that you could use that as sort of like a device. Now when you listen to him play it, it doesn't sound like that but believe me, I know for a fact that that was something that he discovered.

MR: That was — you basically answered my next question then. That that wasn't an accident for him.

KJ: Oh no. I mean he really understood how they were functioning. So you could you know like in other words like sometimes in theory somebody might say you know when you play a dominant seventh you can play this scale, you can play that scale. And you can, there's all kinds of scales that you can play against these things. But what you have to find out is how they're functioning, what their true function is in the context that you're trying to deal with it you see. And when you start analyzing like that then you come up with like, I like to just define as the line, you know the connection between all these different things.

MR: I'm not quite sure I understand what you mean by how they function.

KJ: In other words like you know form follows function, you know, you've heard that a million times from architecture? Well architects, it's the same in music, you know it does. In other words given that context, the dominant seventh was really functioning really more for him like a minor eleventh, you see?

MR: It was sounding —

KJ: If you think about that, in other words if you think about a dominant seventh, right, a C7, but now think about it functioning more like a B-flat minor eleventh.

MR: Okay.

KJ: It's different. It's a different sound. So in other words you may not play C-E-G-B-flat or some variation of a sharp eleventh or a flat ninth. Now you're talking about well you

mean? You have like another color that you can actually deal with and a different function that you can actually deal with.

MR: If you're doing that kind of thing do you feel compelled to sort of then bring it back to something that sounds less out? You know what I mean by that? I mean some people would play sort of outside the change or add all those things on and then they would sort of bring it back as if I went out there but I'm going to bring you back.

KJ: No I don't think so. I think, you know, in other words, that's the thing, in other words the more that you can make it sound like it's not out or in or whatever, the more that you can make it sound like it's a part of it, then you're doing your job. Because sometimes what happens, somebody'll play something and it's obvious that they're playing it — I mean like think about a lot of the things that Charlie Parker played, I mean he would play a lot of things where, you know, he would play like a half-step above and then resolve it back. He'd create that tension. So it wasn't like he was playing it out for the sake of playing it out, but he was like well this is what I'm hearing. I'm playing it because I'm hearing it this way versus just saying well okay I'm going to play against it. You know play it out and keep it out there. But then you have somebody like my father who will just keep it out as far as he can. And that's his thing because see that fits his personality. You know you can play, man I remember him listening to squeaky doors when I was a little boy, trying to find — he was talking about quarter tones and playing between tones before I even went to school, so like you know I got indoctrination into John Cage and Roger Sessions and you know Stockhausen. I mean you see my beginnings was like with John Coltrane and I remember my dad having Miles Davis doing "The Sorcerer," and John Coltrane playing "Out of this World," and I remember very vividly this composition, this composer, American composer, Henry Brandt, you know "Angles and Devils" flute choir." Really interesting piece. You know bass flutes, alto flutes, piccolos, all kind of flutes, I mean really interesting sound. So he's been dealing with the sound of music for a very long time. Because I mean when you're dealing with rhythm and sound you're going to come up with something interesting, I don't care what kind of music you deal with. If you're dealing with rhythm and sound, you're going to come up with some interesting things. Think about, I mean, how Duke Ellington was composing for his orchestra. You know it was really — I actually haven't really studied his compositional techniques yet but I've been meaning to get to it. I just want to deal with the things that I'm into and so forth.

MR: Well what's it like to try to make a living in music these days?

KJ: In music?

MR: And has it changed a lot that you would think in the last 15, 20 years?

KJ: Oh yes very definitely. I think part of the problem that has happened with music, especially jazz music, and probably all music, is that it's really publicity oriented now. You know it's like somebody may know your name or they may know who you are, but they don't know your music. I'm telling you. I mean I've seen it a thousand times. Well obviously take somebody as famous as Wynton is right now, you know in jazz, and I go to my friends, "Oh yea, I know who Wynton Marsalis, I know who Wynton Marsalis is." And I'll say, "Okay really?" "Yeah." At least they may know that he plays the trumpet. I give them credit for that. And I say, "Well do you know any of his compositions? Do you know of a CD that he may have made or any of his music?" And they say, "No I may not know that but I know who he is." Whereas before, you know, maybe people would say yeah, well I can name his composition, I know this CD or I went to the place or the performance or the club and heard this music. It's not the same. I think people, now, with soccer moms and I'm a father myself and kids going to college and all these other things that people have to deal with on a day to day basis, it's very difficult now I think, to deal with cultural issues. Culture now is well you know is there a mother and a father in the home or two women in the home or two men in the home. That's quote unquote a culture issue now. You know? Or is it that you — what's another cultural issue, you know I'm trying to think of the things that have sort of been put out there as Americans losing their culture. You know, it's more a political kind of a culture versus an artistic type of a culture.

MR: Yeah. Abortion or pro-abortion.

KJ: Abortion or pro-abortion, all kinds of issues, war and not war. Whereas before maybe you were dealing with those things in very subtle ways but I think parents made sure that their kids went to musical performances, whether that was jazz, classical music or whatever, they went to movies, they weren't buying DVDs or videos, you know what I mean?

MR: It was more of an event.

KJ: Exactly. It was event-driven. Now you know with the advent of the internet — which is good because I love the internet in terms of sort of the like the universality of it, but in a way because of the mass communication of things, because we get our information so spontaneous now and so quickly now, we've lost what it really means to go to an event or to go to a happening or to see something new and different, just because there's so much information out there and people are dealing with life in a very — how can I say it — anticipatory — it's sort of like it's on the edge all the time. You know you can't really get a chance to really relax and enjoy yourself as much as you can. I mean I have this thing that I say like sometimes when I'm telling my musician friends about doing certain things

want to deal with the office today, I want to go and have a nice meal, find a babysitter for my kids, go to a movie, go listen to some music and just chill." And then they go to the club and the musicians are like, "Man I don't want to be here tonight." So you know that's why the executives are trying to get away and the musicians are trying to get away at the same time.

MR: I know exactly what you're saying. We had someone at Hamilton — I won't mention names — but a working jazz musician who we were thinking that's what we want to do. And he's thinking, "I want your gig, I want to get a college gig and have that security and all that." Whatever.

KJ: Right. Because the road gets tired and maybe playing — I'm telling you we're at a crossroads in our culture now. I mean we have to really make a decision in terms of who we're going to be and what we're going to be and how we're going to be and it's out there. We really are there now. So somebody has to come forward, or certain people have to come forward and say this is really how it should be. And not necessarily for everybody but this is how it is for me, I still want to perform. I think, you know, the interesting thing about the internet is I think what it will do is it will make people performers again, where you just can't go and buy a CD and think — you know it's nice to listen — because the interesting thing about when I listen to this is I remember being in the studio with Ron Carter and Jack DeJohnette and playing with those great musicians. And we were like, we did that in two takes, that was it. We rehearsed it and they'd say okay let's hit it. And so you have to be on it. You have to be ready to play. You can't be around there saying oh, no, they were pushing me. And I loved them for that. And that's what I'm talking about, you know, get back to that thing where, forget about the CDs. The CDs are nice but where you're playing live and the music is spontaneous and let the event dictate the music you know, and make something happen.

MR: Before we actually started we were talking a little bit about how marketing is changing, has changed and will continue to change. You had a release that kind of sat around for a while, "Out of this World"?

KJ: "Out of this World," that's right.

MR: Yeah.

KJ: I'll have to get that to you, I'm sorry I didn't bring any of that music with me because I was really just concentrating on what I had to do here. Yeah I did it and it was a really, I think probably like some of the best playing in terms of what I wanted to convey. And obviously we did "Out of this World" that was influenced by John Coltrane. It's not his composition but we — I say we — but Elton Herron who is a great colleague and a friend and a relative, arranged it for me and it's just one of those things, one of those sessions,

after the tape started rolling I gave everything I could give at that moment. And then I had to go on to something else. And with the recording industry changing now you really sort of have to pick your moments when you want to go in and do something that's of value versus let me go into the studio and do a CD because I don't want people to forget about me. I don't really operate like that. You know, just come up with some tunes. For me it's kind of a process and then when I'm there I'll go yes, let's go in and do something.

MR: So you're going to try to market that yourself?

KJ: Yeah I mean I just think — I hate to say this and maybe I hope the archive proves me wrong — but I think CDs are over. Records will become for collectors. I think we're going to be dealing with sound files. I think with the advent of the internet you can find your audience or you can find your consumer without having to put a lot of money into it, without having to do anything differently. I think the companies are realizing that now. I think they're trying to figure out well how do we keep this thing afloat and I just think, for jazz anyway, I mean we have to find our own audience now. We have to recreate that thing because the sales just aren't strong enough to support these labels out here to do these, the amount of music, In other words to support the kind of sales that they have to make to support their labels.

MR: Their investments.

KJ: Yeah, their investment. I mean it's obvious to anybody whose — and that's a good thing because I think it makes us more independent. You know I think the music will be stronger, it should actually be more adventuresome, it should be different. I thought what happened in sort of like in the late nineties or in the early eighties was — I'm sure that you found this to be the same thing — there were so many CDs that were coming out where they were all the same format, very few people were trying to do different things and you know it was like trumpet, saxophone, rhythm section. Maybe vocals. Rhythm section. Or you may have someone who might have been adventuresome and did something with strings or try to put a different combination together, but I found like the sameness to be so — I mean they found a formula that sort of like worked and then everybody was sort of like on the same thing. And that in a way I think — not destroyed it but it's sort of like a missed opportunity. Because think about it. I mean even when Blue Note was at its zenith you could pick up a Dexter Gordon record and know it was Dexter. You could pick up a Wayne Shorter record and it was Wayne. You pick up a Hank Mobley album and you knew it was Hank. Now, man I'm telling you, I listen to a lot of these saxophone players and I'm like man, I can not tell if it's Michael Brecker playing or if it's Michael Brecker playing — that's a joke.

KJ: Because you know what happens is a person is not really searching for their sound. I mean as much as John Coltrane loved Dexter Gordon and Sonny Rollins and he would tell you he loved everybody because he was influenced by all these people. I mean I'll never forget somebody was interviewing him and he was saying well who's your influences and he said, "Well I love Dexter and I love Sonny Rollins," and he said, "really everybody." I mean there was nobody that did not influence him. And I remember my father telling a very poignant story, he said he and John were in Detroit one night and they went around the corner to go hear Junior Walker play. And it was like he said John Coltrane said, "Man how does Junior Walker play those high A's on his back like that." And he said, "I'd give my left arm to play a high — I mean it is just so effortless. He said how does he do that? Because he was checking out Junior Walker. He said you would never think that. But that's the kind of musician he was. He wasn't this person who — as great as he was he realized his greatness came from everybody, his influences. So he never wanted to lose that. And I think now what happens is like these kids are so quick and they grasp concepts and they go to school now and like you say you have the fake books, you have the transcribed solos, you have all of this information but you lose your identity. And it's something that you have to really be careful of because when I was coming up we had to transcribe solos, you know we wrote them out and then we did the whole nine, but it was more for analysis versus well I want to sound like John, I want to sound like Hubert, I want to sound like whomever — Miles. We did it because that's how musicians learned off the CDs during that time, or LPs. So you play along with the record, you learn it and then in the way you morph into your own thing versus you know verbatim. And you know Michael Brecker, he's a friend of mine, he said the same thing. He was telling a lot of the young kids now man don't play like me. Find somebody, find your own voice, find what you need to do but don't — you have to find your thing that makes you feel good. And sometimes that's a very difficult thing to tell young musicians that they have to find their own voice. You have to start working on that very early.

MR: You think that we're turning out thousands of jazz degree-holding musicians every year now. What are they going to do?

KJ: Well that's an interesting thing and I thought about that a lot. That's an interesting theory in the stock market if you know, if you ever dabble in that, and that theory is all of the information is already priced. Everybody's given the same information at the same time. So the means is always constant. There's no new information being introduced. So the only way that you can really make money in the market is you have to make it by mistake. Somebody has to make a mistake. You see where I'm going? So all these degrees that are coming online like you're saying, is basically everybody learning the

out if you want, I mean just go and say what did you learn at Berklee? Or what did you learn at UC or what did you learn in Miami or what did you learn and what did you learn and what did you learn. Consequently, you'll be surprised, and I've done it in an anecdotal kind of a way. And basically everybody's learning the same information. Now there's something good in that but what you have to do is you have to sort of take that information and how do you take that and make it your own thing? In other words there's no accident that Monk is different than Duke Ellington even though they learned the same thing. Or think about it, think about Red Garland, Wynton Kelly, Bill Evans, Stan Getz, you know I mean you could have like, that was such an interesting thing to me because they're learning the same information but wow I could tell Dexter from Sonny from Trane from Sonny Stitt. You know what I mean? But now it's like it's a really weird kind of a thing. And I think it's affected the music in that the consumer, or I should say the novice or the neophyte, when he listens, he can't make that subtle distinction between Sonny Rollins or John Coltrane or Hank Mobley or Michael Brecker anymore. It's like it's a saxophone. It sounds the same to me. You see what I mean? It's a saxophone or it's a flute. I'm telling you, I've seen it a thousand times. You know well no, that's just an alto saxophone, now whether it's Cannonball Adderley, Dave Koz, Donald Harrison, try it yourself. Put on, I don't care, you can put on a thousand CDs for some of your, you know like people who really don't follow the music, or people who follow the music, and I'll guarantee you they could not tell you, I mean like the newer stuff, who it really is. I know. I was listening to a CD, I don't want to mention any names, and I was saying man I can't, I really could not discern who it was. Whereas before, I'm telling you man you put on a CD and I could tell you, Joe Henderson, I mean three notes and I knew it was Joe Henderson. Three notes. Without fail. I knew it was John. Three notes I knew it was Sonny Rollins. It didn't take me like a whole entire tune to figure out who was performing. Now you put it on I'm like —

MR: You know what I miss partly, that I think had something to with learning about people is reading the back of record jackets.

KJ: That's exactly right.

MR: Somehow you got more connected to that artist because the whole, it was part of it. And thumbing through and you could stand in the store and read the back of it too you know.

KJ: And that was part of the educational process.

MR: That's right.

KJ: You see? So now you lose that connection, you lose these little subtleties that are sort of like the glue that holds all of these things together. And so it just becomes like this constant little thing that just happens over a period of time. It may be you know we have

about it I think when it became more like a cultural artsy kind of thing we lost that connection between the people. Sometimes those things can happen, you know, where I mean you go to like a jazz club now man, you're not going to see as many black people as you saw like twenty, thirty years ago. You know what I'm saying is true. You go to concerts now, you know? I mean I'm just telling you the truth.

MR: I know.

KJ: It's just what it is so you've lost that connection with the community. You know? And we have to get back to introducing — it's not foreign you know like some of the hip hop artists if you want to call them that, or acts or whatever you want to say. They know about it in a way because they sample it and they're trying to figure it out. Because they're not really creators of music they're samplers of music. And that's not a bad thing, I'm not trying to knock them but believe me they're not trying to analyze a John Coltrane solo. They might like it and say I can use it in their own little way but they're not trying to figure out, you know what I mean — "Giant Steps" or "Countdown," — that's not their thing. It's what it is man.

MR: Well I'm curious if you ran into any — even teaching at NOCCA and that kind of thing, did you run into any academia political type things once you get into education?

KJ: Well actually yea, I quit NOCCA and now I'm starting like another arts-based school, well I should say, I'm sorry, I resigned. That's politically more correct. And actually Alvin Batiste took my place when I left NOCCA. And I feel like there's two things that should happen when you talk about academia. Part of it is that when you get into academia or in a situation where you can teach you should try to practice more and study more and play more. Even though your time is dedicated to obviously teaching. Now the reason why I say that is because you can lose your edge versus even when you're performing more, you see what I'm saying, you should study more and do those other things just because you're out there every night maybe on the road or you're playing a little bit more you lose the edge in terms of the analysis or trying to think about things differently. Just because now it has become playing every night or traveling or whatever it is you're going to do. So there's tradeoffs. So in terms of the academia I think the political thing is is that everybody's trying to figure out what they can offer that may be a little bit differently from the other arts-based type things, you know, if you're at the high school level. Obviously when you get to the college level it becomes about well if you have a Kenny Barron or if you have a Wynton Marsalis or whoever you have, a Terence Blanchard or whoever you have on your staff as part of your faculty people are attracted to that. But I find, you know, there again, it's really if you get a great teacher. Somebody who can really teach you your instrument, somebody who can point you in the right

this because I heard this the other night or I read about this or this is something that you may find interesting because you're interested in this. You know what I mean? To me that's what's important. Not that you can think of another class to offer because it sounds good in your course offerings, but to really come up with people who really are knowledgeable. And what I mean by that is where they can point you in the right direction. Because nobody has a monopoly on information. You know what I mean? I mean as great as Berklee School of Music is there are things that's probably being lost in the cracks that you know they can offer, if they can find somebody or find something where somebody's doing something a little bit different. And sometimes even at these smaller institutions, like what you guys are doing. I mean I don't see this happening at Harvard or quote unquote institutions that have jazz degrees. See I'm really, I pick up on all those type of subtleties because we have a tendency to just look at the big picture and not look at what's really happening.

MR: What's happening in the near future for you?

KJ: After this I have to get back because the CEO of my school — well obviously I'm from New Orleans so you know about the transition that we're going through. I was fortunate I didn't lose my house. I live in a section of town that was actually was settled before New Orleans, it's called Algiers. Some people refer to it as Old Algiers and we call it Algiers Point. It's across the river.

MR: Across the river, yeah.

KJ: And as you know about the history of the music, there was a lot of jazz musicians who settled in Algiers who perform. I mean we have this walk of fame, in fact there's a statue of Louis Armstrong right at Algiers Point. And it's really interesting because you can take the ferry and cross the river and you can be right in the French Quarter from my house. And when I evacuated I stayed away for about two or three months in Florida, I was in Florida with my wife and my son and we went back three months later and — well actually I went back before then and I had to rake up like fifty bags of leaves. I'll never forget it man, it was like I said there's a house here somewhere. But no water.

MR: What was covering your house?

KJ: Leaves. Like I had like leaves like I live under these oak trees I mean it's a beautiful street it's like this avenue. And it's like these 300 year old oak trees. Some of them fell obviously from the wind breaking, but what happened was all of the wind just pushed all the leaves on my front porch. I'm telling you man, I had to like open the gate, move a tree branch, move the leaves out of the way, it was incredible, and open up my front door and I thought I was going to smell this wretched smell coming through my house but what happened was the electricity went out but it was turned back on so the refrigerator was

of my house and that was it, you know, decorative tiles on my roof. That was it. I mean I was thankful. I mean in relation to everybody else who lost everything. My parents lost their houses, my sisters lost their houses, only one brother, believe it or not who lived in a part of town that really flooded but his house was fine. But it was unbelievable, truly. I mean until you see it for yourself or saw it for yourself during that time you would have thought an atomic bomb had been dropped in New Orleans, it was just that bad when I came back. But now the city is in a recovery mode. And actually part of my teaching was that I said well let me go back to see how I can help the city deal with what we've lost because we truly lost a lot of musicians. I mean there's people like the Nevilles who say they're never going back. Some of them say that they're not going to go back. And so we are at a crossroads for lack of a better definition in terms of our culture, in terms of our infrastructure, in terms of where we are, where we were then, even where we are now, how do we rebuild. That question as you know is sort of still being flushed out there. And so to make a long story short or a short story longer, we're in a very interesting place right now in terms of the city. And maybe this might be one of those statements, you know, as New Orleans goes maybe as America will follow. What do we value? What do we really truly value about — I think our individuality, about our music, about a lot of things. In this conversation a lot has been lost because even though you might hear about the kind of poverty that existed in New Orleans during Katrina, which was terrible and you have to acknowledge that, the educational system, breakdown in infrastructure, a lot of people don't realize that New Orleans was where one of the first operas was performed in the United States. Obviously you know the birth of jazz. It was an investment banking center at one time, one of our most important ports. There was a lot of history that happened in New Orleans that we sort of forget about in terms of the birth of this nation you know. And it's sort of like in this renaissance or this rebirth that we have to go through I hope that the United States understands that New Orleans still has something to offer. Now what that is we have to define that in terms of how we grow out of this. Because it's going to be a growth process, I'm telling you. I mean you know maybe you go down there and you really see it for yourself because it's still, in some way, I don't know if you saw the Spike Lee film or saw portions of it, but it is really a devastating experience just to see entire neighborhoods wiped off the face of the earth you know. And for me you just have to say well what can I do? What can I think or what can I do creatively? You know and that's sort of like — which is interesting about the situation where we are in now because we did the camp in New Orleans and we had half the students, and now we're up here teaching kids. So you know we'll still have something to offer. All is not lost. But it is a really wrenching kind of a thing, just for people who have

material possessions. But I'll give you an example. Entire families have lost photographs. So how do you — you know what I mean? How do you give that back to somebody? You know you can give them a house, you can give them a car, you can give them all the things that make them function, but when they sit back and they start talking about the photographs that they lost or the house where they grew up in that their mothers, grandfathers and you've done all these things. You know what I mean? That's something, that emotional tie that you have to figure it out. You have to figure it out because there was something lost but then there's something that has to be either gained or regained again. And that's sort of like what we're going through right now.

MR: Well probably it definitely will be different and I hope it's better.

KJ: Oh yeah.

MR: I hope it comes out with a character, like you said, maybe the country can follow the character of that place somehow.

KJ: Yeah. Somehow we can get back to — I don't know see for me music is just real. It has to have a certain, not a surrealness about it but a realness about it, that can make you feel something, really make you feel something. And I hope that we can regain that. Because truly I can tell you there was certain things that were happening even musically, as great as it is musically there were certain things that were not happening that needed to happen musically that we needed to, in a way, refocus on, you know refocus in on and try to find that verve again. Try to find that character. Because we were just sort of like floating out there, not really taking care of the kind of business that we need to take care of. Now I'm not talking about business in the sense of business sense but a sense of great musicianship. Playing in tune. Reading music. Fundamental things that my dad talks about all the time. That was being lost I'm telling you. You know you go listen to a marching band in New Orleans and it sounded like man —

MR: Where is the craftsmanship?

KJ: Yeah where's the craftsmanship? You know. Where is the musicianship? You know what are they learning. You see I'm telling you man a long time ago with these band directors, you have to play in tune, you have to play correctly, you have to have good posture, good musicianship. I mean man it was just like I'm sure if you haven't, just ask any New Orleanean about Yvonne Bush. I don't know if you've ever heard her but she was a preeminent band director who taught all of the musicians in New Orleans from everybody who played with Fats Domino to you know Ellis Marsalis, Harold Batiste, I mean Yvonne Bush. I'm telling you man. And so when you saw them lose that kind of direction in terms of what you're doing and these kids are going to these schools and not really learning like what you said the craftsmanship, a lot is lost, a lot is lost. So we're

MR: Well I hope you play an important role in all that. And I have a feeling you will somehow or other.

KJ: Yeah. Well what's new for me and I'll just put this in the archive, I'm trying to actually work on my flute and strings project, I'd like to put that out there again. And it something that it's really been a while since I've done it and obviously I'm doing things with my family, you know, Marlon and my sister Stephanie and Rachel, we're doing some things and so hopefully we'll be up here soon doing that.

MR: Well it's been a great time for me to have this conversation with you, I appreciate it.

KJ: Oh I appreciate it. Thank you very much.

MR: Thank you.

KJ: Thank you.